



The Pastoral Spiral

An Ignatian Approach to Deepening
Social Justice Action

The Origins of the Spiral

Cardinal Joseph Cardijn

The foundational
“see, judge, act”
method.

Juan Luis Segundo

The sociological
“hermeneutic
circle”.

The Pastoral Spiral

Formalized by Joe Holland
& Peter Henriot SJ

First described in *Social Analysis*
(Centre of Concern, 1980)

Revised as *Social Analysis:
Linking Faith & Justice*
(Orbis, 1983)

Catholic Social Teaching

The methodology of
modern structural
justice.

St. Ignatius of Loyola

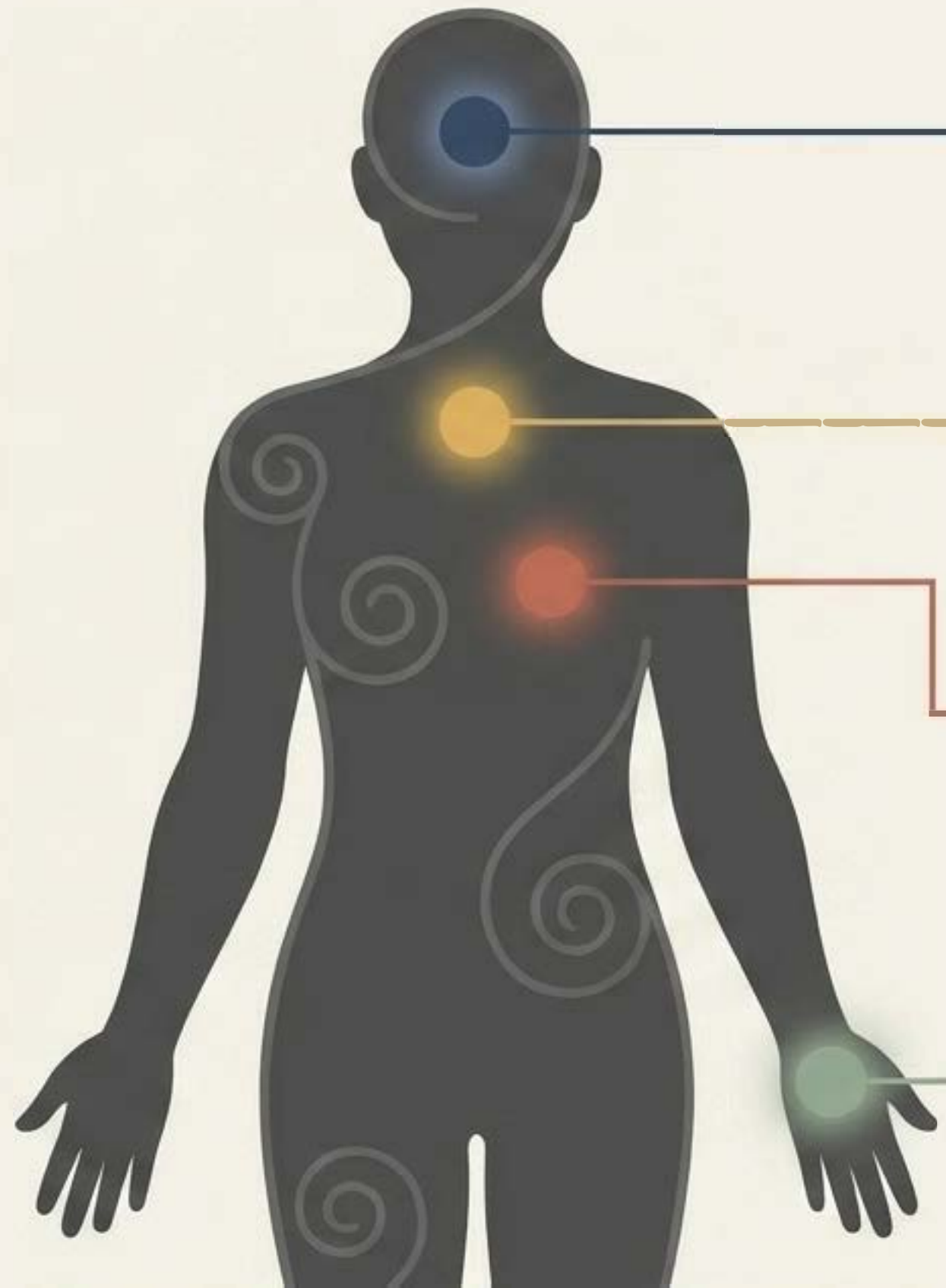
The spirituality of
discernment and
finding God in all
things.

The 4-Quadrant Spiral Matrix



A flexible framework designed for pastoral, academic, or community action purposes.

The Anatomy of Action



Cognitive Dimension

Connects to Analysis. Data and analysis help us achieve better understanding—using our heads.

Volitional Dimension

Connects to Reflection. Getting in touch with deeper values—aligning our heads and hearts with the will of God.

Affective Dimension

Connects to Experience. Immersion helps us get in touch with our feelings—paying attention to our hearts.

Effective Dimension

Connects to Response. Planning for improved responses to situations—using our hands.

1. Experience: Contemplatives in Action

We start from the contemplation of our world,
from the raw data of human experience.



Describing the Problem

What is the lived
experience? What is
happening to people?

Authentic Listening

Are we listening to
the people most
directly affected?

Proximity

Can we share their
experience? Do we
need to undertake
exposure or immersion?



2. Analysis: Called to Learned Ministry

Head



We take reality very seriously, as this is where God continues to act. We investigate in a systematic and analytical way.

Historical, political, economic, social, or cultural roots.

Causes

Downstream effects on the marginalized.

Consequences

How are these disparate elements connected?

Linkages

Who holds power? (Subjects, duty bearers, agents of influence, decision-makers).

Key Actors



3. Theological Reflection: Finding God in All Things

We reflect on the analytical data in the light of the Gospel, Church teaching, and our prayer.

Core/Soul

Are Gospel values being upheld or denied?

How do the Scriptures and the principles of CST speak to this issue?

Where is God in all this?

What does official Church teaching have to say?

How can the historical experience of the Christian community aid our discernment?

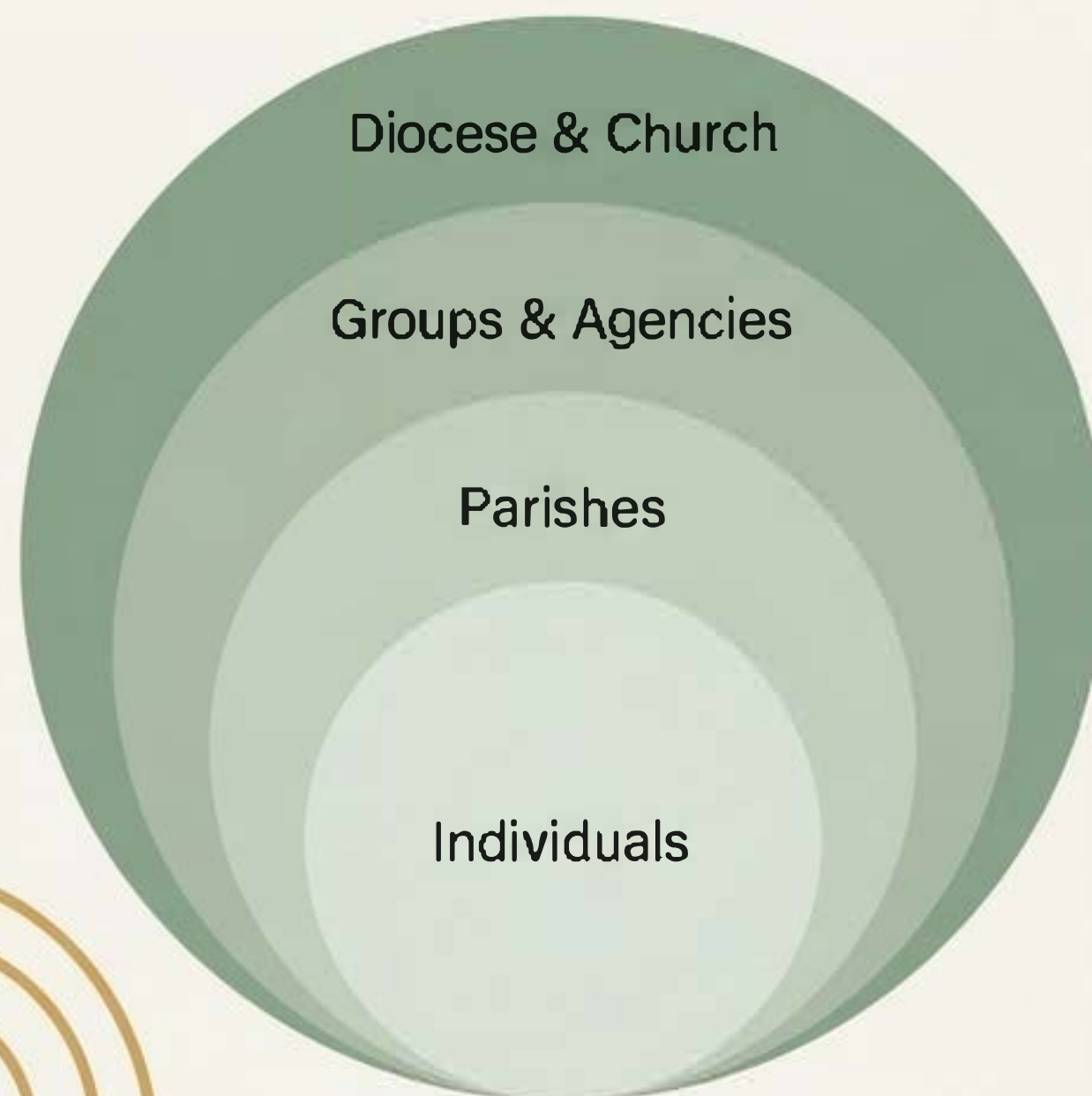




4. Response: Discerning God's Call

We draw on reason, human knowledge, and tradition to discern our love response to God's calls to us.

Scales of Action



The Four Modes of Action

Service of
the poor or
marginalized.

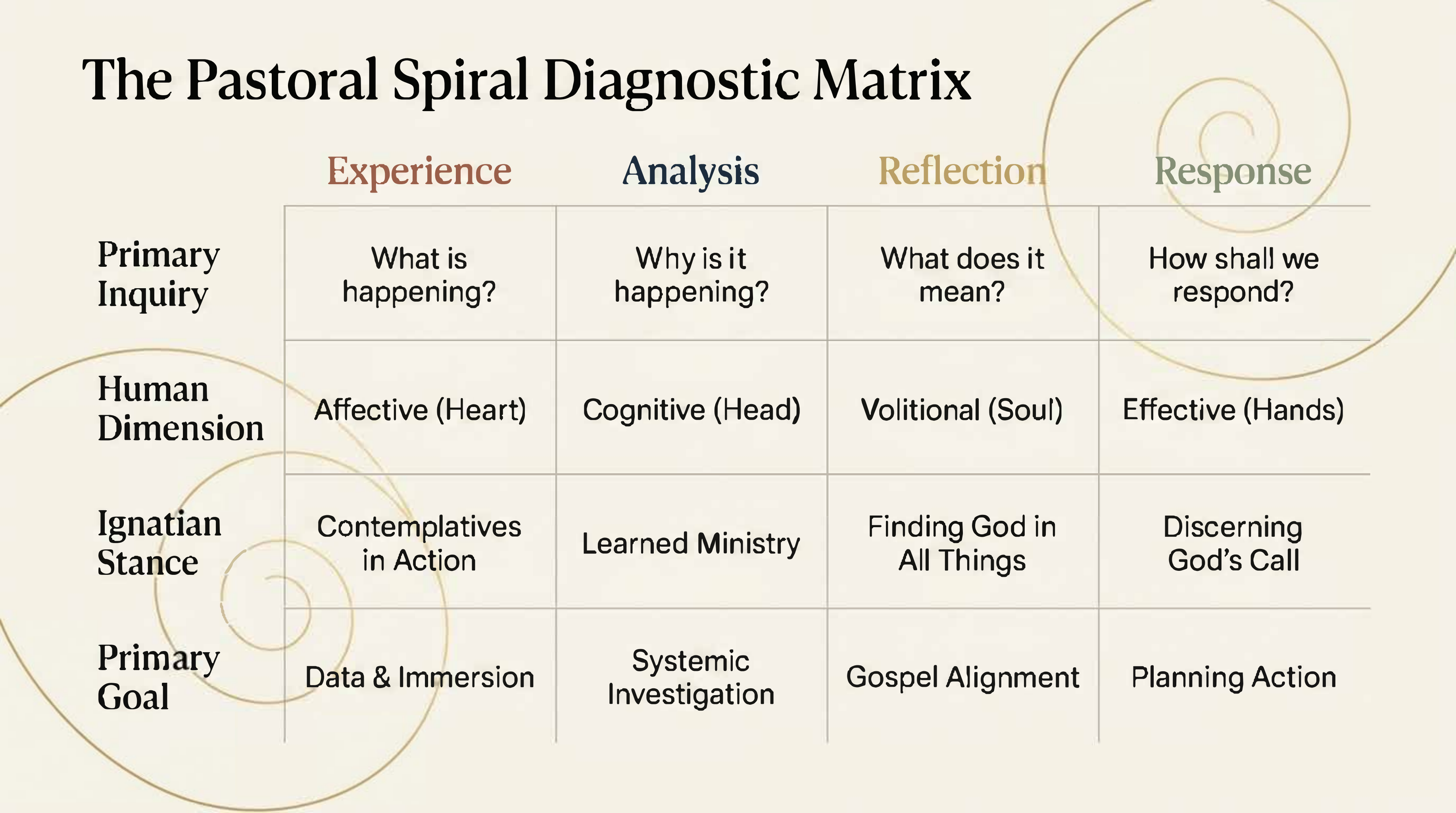
Education or
awareness
raising.

Advocacy &
transformation
of causes.

Faith
formation.



The Pastoral Spiral Diagnostic Matrix



Experience

Analysis

Reflection

Response

Primary Inquiry

What is happening?

Why is it happening?

What does it mean?

How shall we respond?

Human Dimension

Affective (Heart)

Cognitive (Head)

Volitional (Soul)

Effective (Hands)

Ignatian Stance

Contemplatives in Action

Learned Ministry

Finding God in All Things

Discerning God's Call

Primary Goal

Data & Immersion

Systemic Investigation

Gospel Alignment

Planning Action

Going Round Again: Seeking the Magis

Analysis Paralysis



Waiting for perfect information traps us. Make modest responses based on what is currently known; responses will never be perfect or complete.

The Upward Elevation



Action alters reality. We must evaluate our action: Has this changed the situation? What is happening now? We continually seek the magis—to go deeper and be of ever greater service.

Evaluating Our Work: The GC34 Mandate

At the 34th General Congregation, the Society of Jesus decreed that every ministry can and should promote justice in one or more of these ways (Decree 3, n 19):



🔗 Accompaniment

Direct service and accompaniment of the poor.

🔗 Awareness

Developing awareness of the demands of justice joined to the responsibility to achieve it.

🔗 Mobilization

Participating in social mobilization for the creation of a more just social order.

**Does our way of working touch every moment of the Spiral?
Does our action correspond to these demands of justice?**